

Trying It Again

Failure has a tendency to feed into failure. When a character fails to start a car in a suspenseful, dramatic moment, stress fuels the next attempt, and with stress comes haste and a likelihood of increased failure. In such cases the Storyteller can increase the difficulty of the second attempt by one, if she so chooses. If the attempt fails yet again, the difficulty of a third attempt increases by one again, and so on. Eventually, the difficulty increases to a point that attempts are fruitless.

Examples of when to use this rule are: picking a lock, resisting interrogation, or attempting to remember lines and lyrics. If you cannot turn the tumblers, withstand the pressure, or have immediate recall of the script, you may not be able to do it at all.

Do not invoke this rule in cases when expecting multiple attempts at success, such as when tracking an enemy, trying to outthink an intruder, or firing a gun. Failure in these scenarios does not automatically lead to frustration and failed future attempts.

Example: *Your character is attempting to mediate an assembly of Kithain Traditionalists, Reformers, and Modernists, as they debate the current state of the nobility. Tempers become frayed and a redcap among the Modernists begins to make violent overtures. You roll Expression + Charisma (difficulty 7) for your character to make her voice heard and calm the congress down, getting a 2, 3, 5, 5, 6, 6. The nobles barely notice your failure as some start screaming at each other, while others reach for weapons. Your character's stress levels build — she didn't expect this escalation — and attempting again to pacify the dignitaries, you roll Expression + Charisma, the difficulty now increased by 1 (difficulty 8). You get 1, 4, 7, 8, 8, 10. After deducting one of the 8s due to your roll of 1, you still manage two successes. The crowd begins to quiet, but they will not remain that way for long.*

Complications

For the majority of games, the preceding rules should be all you ever need. They do not cover all eventualities — for instance, what if a character attempts to match wits in a game of death with a Sicilian Unseelie boggan, or wishes to spend several days studying in a dusty old library to find out the truth behind the rumors of fae vampires?

The below complications exist to add more color, realism, and suspense to games, but they are optional, so don't feel the need to memorize them if they seem unnecessary to your chronicle.

The following complications are relatively simple and generic, usable to describe a wide variety of actions. For situation-specific complications, see Chapter Six.

Extended Actions

Completing some tasks can take longer than a single turn. When you need multiple successes to score even a marginal success, you are undertaking an extended action. For example, a boggan spends a whole night in a bar listening to a satyr grump ramble on about his journey to the Deep Dreaming, just to catch one or two useful nuggets of information in amongst the

hyperbolic tales of derring-do. A sidhe may be attempting to remain composed during a humiliating House ritual, and knows if she breaks at any point during the rite, she will have failed.

For extended actions, the character's dice pool is rolled multiple times at subsequent intervals, trying to collect enough successes to succeed. In the above barroom example, the boggan has to gain 10 successes to sort the verbal wheat from the chaff. He will probably succeed eventually, but the longer it takes, the more chances the satyr rambles off on tangents or the boggan just records the wrong information. In this example, bar closing time limits the number of turns available, making the speed with which the task is finished increasingly important. The Storyteller in all cases is the final authority on which tasks are extended actions.

Providing nothing prevents the actions from taking place, extended actions can take as long as they need. In the case of a botch, however, all accumulated successes are lost. The satyr angrily accuses the boggan of not listening to every word of his thrilling tale, making the boggan start over from scratch as the story recommences from the beginning once the satyr composes himself. The Storyteller may rule that some extended actions cannot be restarted once failed.

Because extended actions are the best means for recording certain feats, the systems in Chapter Six use them frequently. Due to the amount of dice-rolling involved, pick and choose when extended actions are most appropriate to the flow of play.

Note that extended actions may be on a different frequency than turn-by-turn. The Storyteller determines the unit of time over which the action takes place. In the sidhe ritual example above, the rite actually lasts a week and entails resisting various arcane practices across that time. Alternatively, the rite could be finished within a day, or an hour, if that is what the Storyteller believes is best for the chronicle. For more information on time intervals and how they relate to game systems, see p. 248.

Example: *Your sluagh escapes the laboratory with the unconscious baron's heir over his shoulder. Everything is going so well until the alarm goes off, the floodlights come on, and the sounds of security guards' booted feet come tramping out the building. You decide your character's best bet is to flee into the nearby woods with the heir in tow, find a safe place to hide, and wait out the night. The Storyteller says that for you to do this, you need to score 15 successes on an extended Wits + Survival roll (difficulty 7). Additionally, as it is still early evening and you have the whole night ahead, with the guards no doubt combing the woodlands for you and your quarry all night, you can only roll once per hour, over the next nine hours.*

Your sluagh has Wits 4 and Survival 2, so you roll six dice each hour of game time. The first roll is a bust as you receive a botch, but thankfully, it's before it can wipe out any of your successes, as you've yet to score any. Your changeling must move deeper into the woods, otherwise risking discovery (in system terms, you succeed on a Dexterity + Stealth roll). On your second roll, you get four successes, which is much better. The third roll takes you up to seven successes, but the fourth is a failure. You know you have another five attempts to make eight more successes, but one botch is enough to have the guards stumble upon your hidey-hole. Your sluagh has seen the inside of that lab, and he has no interest in going back.